Ladder Inspection Checklist (29 CFR 1926.1053)

For periodic competent-person inspections and after any occurrence that may have damaged or disturbed a ladder.

OSHA 29 CFR 1926.1053

DATE	SHIFT
INSPECTOR	AREA / EQUIPMENT ID

Before you start

1. Mark every item OK, Defect or N/A.
2. If a ladder has a structural defect, mark it as defective or tag it "Do Not Use" and keep it out of service until it is repaired (1926.1053(b)(16) and (b)(17)).
3. Record any other failed set-up or use item and correct it before the ladder is used.

Legal basis: 29 CFR 1926.1053: Ladders (Part 1926, Subpart X: Stairways and Ladders) Source: eCFR, Title 29, text as of 2026-11-09
Online version and sources: https://safetyindex.blog/us/standards/1926-1053-ladders

SECTION A | Condition of portable ladders

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
1	Competent-person inspection Ref. 1926.1053(b)(15)	A competent person has checked the ladder for visible defects as part of periodic inspections and after any event that might have affected it	☐	☐	☐	
2	Rungs, cleats and steps Ref. 1926.1053(b)(16)	None broken or missing	☐	☐	☐	
3	Rung alignment Ref. 1926.1053(a)(2)	Rungs, cleats and steps parallel, level and uniformly spaced with the ladder in position for use	☐	☐	☐	
4	Side rails Ref. 1926.1053(b)(16)	No broken or split rails and no corroded components	☐	☐	☐	
5	Defective ladder handling Ref. 1926.1053(b)(16)	Any ladder with a structural defect is marked as defective or tagged "Do Not Use" and kept out of service until repaired	☐	☐	☐	
6	Slip treatment on metal rungs Ref. 1926.1053(a)(6)(ii)	Rungs and steps corrugated, knurled, dimpled, skid-resistant coated or otherwise treated	☐	☐	☐	
7	Component surfaces Ref. 1926.1053(a)(11)	No surface that could puncture or cut a worker or snag clothing	☐	☐	☐	
8	Wood ladder finish Ref. 1926.1053(a)(12)	No opaque paint or covering; labels only on one face of a side rail	☐	☐	☐	
9	Slipping hazards Ref. 1926.1053(b)(2)	Rungs, steps and rails clean of oil, grease and other slippery material	☐	☐	☐	
10	Repairs Ref. 1926.1053(b)(18)	Repaired ladders restored to their original design criteria before reuse	☐	☐	☐	

SECTION B | Stepladders

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
11	Spreader or lock Ref. 1926.1053(a)(8)	Metal spreader or locking device present and engaged, holding front and back sections open	☐	☐	☐	

General guidance only, not legal advice. Check the current regulation and your employer's procedures.

SECTION B | Stepladders

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
12	Top and top step Ref. 1926.1053(b)(13)	Nobody standing on the top or top step	☐	☐	☐	
13	Rear cross-bracing Ref. 1926.1053(b)(14)	Rear bracing not climbed unless the ladder has steps on both front and rear sections	☐	☐	☐	

SECTION C | Set-up and placement

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
14	Extension above landing Ref. 1926.1053(b)(1)	Side rails reach 3 feet or more above the upper landing, or the top is secured to a rigid non-deflecting support with a grabrail or other grasping device	☐	☐	☐	
15	Ladder angle Ref. 1926.1053(b)(5)(i)	Horizontal distance from top support to foot about a quarter of the ladder's working length (non-self-supporting ladders)	☐	☐	☐	
16	Spliced job-made ladders Ref. 1926.1053(b)(5)(ii)	Horizontal distance from top support to foot is one-eighth of the working length (wood job-made ladders with spliced side rails)	☐	☐	☐	
17	Top support Ref. 1926.1053(b)(10)	Both rails bearing equally at the top, unless a single support attachment is fitted	☐	☐	☐	
18	Footing Ref. 1926.1053(b)(6)	Stable, level surface, or ladder secured against accidental displacement	☐	☐	☐	
19	Slippery surfaces Ref. 1926.1053(b)(7)	Ladder secured or fitted with slip-resistant feet, and still placed, lashed or held with care	☐	☐	☐	
20	Traffic areas Ref. 1926.1053(b)(8)	In passageways, doorways or driveways, ladder secured or traffic barricaded away	☐	☐	☐	
21	Top and bottom clear Ref. 1926.1053(b)(9)	No materials or debris around the top and bottom of the ladder	☐	☐	☐	
22	Joined ladders Ref. 1926.1053(a)(7)	Ladders not tied or fastened together for length unless designed for it	☐	☐	☐	
23	Multiple ladders Ref. 1926.1053(a)(10)	Separate ladders serving one elevated area offset with a platform or landing between them	☐	☐	☐	

SECTION D | Use and climbing

No.	Check item	What to look for	OK	Defect	N/A	Notes
24	Load Ref. 1926.1053(b)(3)	Ladder not loaded beyond its maximum intended load or the manufacturer's rated capacity	☐	☐	☐	
25	Purpose Ref. 1926.1053(b)(4)	Ladder used only for the purpose it was designed for	☐	☐	☐	
26	Electrical exposure Ref. 1926.1053(b)(12)	Nonconductive siderails where the worker or ladder could contact exposed energized electrical equipment	☐	☐	☐	
27	Occupied ladder Ref. 1926.1053(b)(11)	Ladder not moved, shifted or extended with anyone on it	☐	☐	☐	

General guidance only, not legal advice. Check the current regulation and your employer's procedures.

SECTION D | Use and climbing						
No.	**Check item**	**What to look for**	**OK**	**Defect**	**N/A**	**Notes**
28	Facing the ladder Ref. 1926.1053(b)(20)	Climbers face the ladder going up and down	☐	☐	☐	
29	Handhold Ref. 1926.1053(b)(21)	Climbers hold on with one hand or more while moving	☐	☐	☐	
30	Carried loads Ref. 1926.1053(b)(22)	Nothing carried that could unbalance the climber	☐	☐	☐	
31	Single-rail ladders Ref. 1926.1053(b)(19)	No single-rail ladders in use	☐	☐	☐	

SECTION E | Fixed ladders						
No.	**Check item**	**What to look for**	**OK**	**Defect**	**N/A**	**Notes**
32	Defective fixed ladder Ref. 1926.1053(b)(17)	Ladder with structural defects tagged, marked or blocked and out of service until repaired	☐	☐	☐	
33	Short climb with high top Ref. 1926.1053(a)(18)	Cage, well, ladder safety device or self-retracting lifeline where the top is more than 24 feet above lower levels	☐	☐	☐	
34	Climbs of 24 feet or more Ref. 1926.1053(a)(19)	Ladder safety device; or self-retracting lifelines with rest platforms no more than 150 feet apart; or cage or well with offset sections of 50 feet or less and landing platforms at intervals of 50 feet or less	☐	☐	☐	
35	Clearance behind rungs Ref. 1926.1053(a)(13)	7 inches or more to any obstruction behind the ladder (4 1/2 inches for elevator pit ladders)	☐	☐	☐	
36	Climbing-side clearance Ref. 1926.1053(a)(14)	30 inches or more from rung centerline to obstructions, unless reduced under (a)(15) with a deflection device	☐	☐	☐	
37	Side-rail extension Ref. 1926.1053(a)(24)	Side rails of through or side-step ladders extend 42 inches above the access level or landing platform	☐	☐	☐	
38	Side clearance without cage or well Ref. 1926.1053(a)(17)	15 inches or more clear on each side of the ladder centerline to the nearest permanent object	☐	☐	☐	
39	Pitch Ref. 1926.1053(b)(5)(iii)	Pitch no greater than 90 degrees from horizontal, measured to the back side of the ladder	☐	☐	☐	

General guidance only, not legal advice. Check the current regulation and your employer's procedures.

DEFECTS FOUND AND ACTION TAKEN

Item no.	Defect description	Reported to	Action taken / date closed

SIGN-OFF

SAFE TO OPERATE?	☐ Yes ☐ No: tagged out of service	
INSPECTOR SIGNATURE		DATE / TIME
SUPERVISOR REVIEW		DATE / TIME

General guidance only, not legal advice. Check the current regulation and your employer's procedures.